

A War of Nerves

The Cold War · 1945–1991 | Standards US.59, US.60, US.61, US.62, US.63, US.64, US.65, US.66, US.67, US.68, US.69, US.70

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

For nearly half a century, the two most powerful nations on earth pointed enough weapons at each other to end the world — and never quite fired. The Cold War was fought with spies, propaganda, proxy wars, and fear instead of direct battle. How do you 'win' a war nobody dares to fight? And what does a democracy risk losing — at home — when it spends fifty years afraid?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

Cold War	The 45-year rivalry between the U.S. and USSR — fought with threats, spies, and proxy wars, not direct battle.	containment	The U.S. strategy of stopping the spread of communism.
McCarthyism	Making reckless accusations of disloyalty without evidence, named for Senator Joseph McCarthy.	brinkmanship	Threatening massive (nuclear) retaliation to force an enemy to back down.
MAD (Mutually Assured Destruction)	The idea that neither side would start a nuclear war because both would be destroyed.	proxy war	A conflict (like Korea or Vietnam) where the superpowers fight through other countries rather than each other.
détente	The 1970s easing of Cold War tensions through diplomacy and arms-control treaties.	Iron Curtain	Churchill's name for the divide between the communist East and the democratic West.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze the origins of the Cold War and the U.S. strategy of containment (Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, Berlin Airlift, NATO). Notice: Yesterday's ally is today's enemy. The moment the shooting stopped in 1945, the two nations that had just beaten Hitler together turned to face... Debrief: Explain how the Cold War began and what 'containment' meant. Give two examples of early containment policies and how each worked.	The Cold War began as the U.S. (democracy/capitalism) and USSR (communism) became rival superpowers after WWII, divided by an 'iron curtain,' avoiding direct war due to nuclear weapons. Containment = stopping communism's spread. Examples (any two): Truman Doctrine (aid to nations resisting communism), Marshall Plan (rebuilt Western Europe), Berlin Airlift (supplied West Berlin by air), NATO (permanent alliance). Strong answers explain how each policy served containment.
2	Analyze the Second Red Scare and McCarthyism — HUAC, the blacklist, and the Rosenberg case — as a civil-liberties crisis born of Cold War fear. Notice: Someone points at you and says you're the enemy. They have no proof — just a claim — but the claim alone is enough to get you fired, blacklisted... Debrief: Explain what McCarthyism was and how it harmed Americans, using HUAC and the blacklist. Then explain the tension the Rosenberg case reveals: how can it be true both that Soviet spies existed AND that the Red Scare went too far?	McCarthyism = reckless accusations of communism without evidence; HUAC investigated beliefs and blacklisted 300+ Hollywood artists; thousands lost jobs on suspicion. The Rosenberg case shows the tension: real Soviet espionage existed (Julius spied), yet the climate of fear produced unfair trials and punished many innocent people. Strong answers hold both truths together without dismissing either.
3	Analyze the causes, course, and outcome of the Korean War — containment's first shooting test. Notice: A line on a map, drawn in a hurry, splits a country in two — communist on one side, not on the other. Then one morning the tanks roll across it... Debrief: Explain how the Korean War tested the U.S. strategy of containment, and describe its outcome. Why was Truman's decision to fire MacArthur significant?	North Korea's 1950 invasion tested containment; the U.S. led UN forces to defend the South. Inchon reversed the war, but China's entry created a stalemate, and the 1953 armistice left Korea divided at the 38th parallel. Firing MacArthur (for publicly pushing to widen the war toward China) affirmed civilian control of the military — a core democratic principle. Strong answers connect Korea to containment and note the war's inconclusive result.
4	Analyze Eisenhower's strategy of brinkmanship and the nuclear arms race that filled American life with the fear of sudden annihilation. Notice: Your teacher stops class, and everyone crawls under their desks and covers their heads — practicing for the end of the world. That was a normal... Debrief: Explain Eisenhower's strategy of brinkmanship and the idea of Mutually Assured Destruction (MAD). Then describe two ways nuclear fear shaped everyday American life. What was Eisenhower warning about with the 'military-industrial complex'?	Brinkmanship/massive retaliation used the threat of nuclear response to deter the USSR cheaply; MAD meant neither side would start a nuclear war because both would be destroyed. Everyday effects: duck-and-cover drills, fallout shelters, pervasive nuclear anxiety in culture. Eisenhower warned that the permanent alliance of arms-makers and the military (the 'military-industrial complex') could gain dangerous influence over democracy. Strong answers connect strategy, daily fear, and the warning.
5	Analyze the Space Race as an arena of Cold War competition, from the shock of Sputnik to the Moon landing. Notice: One night in 1957, Americans went outside and looked up — and saw a Soviet machine crossing the sky. A little metal ball called Sputnik, beeping... Debrief: Explain why the launch of Sputnik alarmed Americans and how the U.S. responded. Then explain how the Space Race was really part of the Cold War, using the Moon landing as evidence.	Sputnik (1957) alarmed Americans because rockets that could orbit a satellite could also deliver nuclear weapons, and it suggested Soviet technological superiority. The U.S. responded by creating NASA (1958) and boosting science/math education. It was Cold War competition because winning space (culminating in the 1969 Apollo 11 Moon landing) was meant to prove the superiority of the American system over the Soviet one. Strong answers connect technology, fear, and ideological competition.
6	Analyze the Cuban Revolution, the Bay of Pigs, and the Cuban Missile Crisis — the closest the world came to nuclear war. Notice: Thirteen days. For thirteen days in October 1962, the entire human race was closer to nuclear annihilation than it has ever been before or since —... Debrief: Explain how the Cuban Missile Crisis began and how it was resolved. Why is it considered the most dangerous moment of the Cold War, and what did the two sides do afterward to reduce the risk of nuclear war?	It began when the U.S. discovered Soviet nuclear missiles under construction in Cuba (Oct. 1962), following Castro's communist takeover (1959) and the failed Bay of Pigs (1961). Kennedy imposed a naval blockade; after 13 tense days, Khrushchev removed the missiles in exchange for a U.S. no-invasion pledge and a secret removal of U.S. missiles from Turkey. It was the closest the world came to nuclear war; afterward both sides created the hotline and pursued arms control. Strong answers explain both the danger and the de-escalation.
7	Analyze the causes and course of the Vietnam War and the roles of Kennedy, Johnson, and Nixon in escalating and ending it. Notice: You're nineteen, drafted, and dropped into a jungle on the other side of the planet to fight an enemy you can't see, for a village that isn't sure... Debrief: Explain why the U.S. could not win in Vietnam despite its military superiority. Then summarize how Kennedy, Johnson, and Nixon each handled the war. Why is Linh's perspective important to understanding it?	The U.S. faced a guerrilla war (tunnels, ambushes, jungle, village loyalty) that neutralized its firepower and helicopters, and it couldn't translate battles into lasting political control. Kennedy raised advisers to 16,000; Johnson escalated to 500,000+ (until Tet 1968 turned opinion); Nixon pursued Vietnamization and withdrawal. Linh's (Vietnamese) perspective matters because the war was fought in Vietnamese homes, and the Vietnamese people paid the highest price with the least say. Strong answers include the Vietnamese perspective.
8	Analyze the antiwar movement and the deep divisions the Vietnam War created on the American home front. Notice: For the first time in history, Americans could watch a war on television during dinner — the real thing, blood and all, every single night. And...	Causes of division/antiwar movement: the draft (1969 lottery), nightly televised combat, the 1968 Tet Offensive contradicting government claims, and mounting casualties (plus Kent State, 1970). Some saw protest as betraying soldiers risking their lives;

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
	Debrief: Explain why the Vietnam War so deeply divided the American home front. Give two causes of the antiwar movement, and then explain — fairly — why some Americans saw the protests as betrayal. Can you honor both the soldier and the protester?	others saw the war as morally wrong. A strong answer steelmans both, recognizing that respecting the troops and opposing the war are not necessarily contradictory — the soldier and protester were both caught in the same failed war.
9	Analyze détente and the eventual peaceful end of the Cold War, from Nixon's diplomacy to the fall of the Berlin Wall. Notice: After decades of pointing weapons at each other, the two superpowers did something almost stranger than war: they started talking. And then, one... Debrief: Explain what détente was and give two examples. Then explain how the Cold War finally ended. Why is it significant that it ended largely without direct war between the superpowers?	Détente = easing Cold War tensions through diplomacy; examples: Nixon opening relations with China and signing SALT I (1972); the Reagan-Gorbachev INF Treaty (1987). The Cold War ended as the Soviet economy failed and Gorbachev let Eastern Europe go: the Berlin Wall fell (1989), communist governments collapsed, and the USSR dissolved (1991). Its peaceful end is significant because, despite thousands of nuclear weapons, the feared direct/nuclear war never happened — it ended through diplomacy and internal collapse. Strong answers explain the peaceful resolution.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 7 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **American transport planes at Berlin's Tempelhof Airport during the 1948–49 Berlin Airlift, which supplied 2.5 million blockaded West Berliners entirely by air.**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *These are American planes at Berlin during the 1948–49 airlift, feeding a blockaded city entirely from the air. Ask: the U.S. beat the Berlin...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.59/60. Treat both superpowers' fears as real. Establish 'cold' war vs. shooting war. TN anchor: Oak Ridge as the Cold War nuclear engine.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1948	The Berlin Airlift	Climb Broadly regarded as an early Cold War success — resisting Soviet pressure and saving a free city without firing a shot.
1950	The Korean War	Mixed Genuinely debated — containment held and South Korea survived, but at heavy cost and with no clear victory — so it is marked mixed and contested.
1954	The peak of McCarthyism	Setback Broadly recognized as a civil-liberties disgrace in which fear overrode due process — an unambiguous setback for the founding promise.
1962	The Cuban Missile Crisis	Mixed Both an escape from catastrophe and proof of how close the arms race brought the world to disaster — genuinely debated, so marked mixed and contested.
1969	Apollo 11 lands on the Moon	Climb Broadly celebrated as one of humanity's greatest achievements and a Cold War triumph for the United States.
1975	The fall of Saigon ends the Vietnam War	Setback Widely seen as a costly American defeat and national trauma, though its lessons remain debated — so consensus is marked contested.
1989	The Berlin Wall falls	Climb Broadly celebrated as a triumph of freedom and a peaceful end to a 45-year standoff.

B Debrief & Closing Argument

The Cold War is the 'more perfect union' question turned inward. For nearly fifty years, the United States told the world it stood for freedom...

Closing question: The Cold War asked Americans to defend freedom abroad while fear tempted them to shrink it at home. Choose one example where the U.S. lived up to its ideals in the Cold War and one where fear led it to betray them, and argue what the whole era did to the nation's founding promise. Then take a position: did the U.S. 'win' the Cold War, and at what cost? Cite the unit — there's no answer key.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.